

Partnership Intelligence Profile

Atrium Health

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill — Office of Innovation and Commercialization

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Overview

Atrium Health is the Southeast operations unit of Advocate Health, the nation's third-largest nonprofit integrated health system. Atrium Health operates under its historical legal structure as the Charlotte-Mecklenburg Hospital Authority, a North Carolina public body headquartered in Charlotte, and spans 40 hospitals and more than 500 care locations across North Carolina, South Carolina, Georgia, and Alabama. Its academic and research functions are anchored by Wake Forest University School of Medicine, which joined Atrium in 2020 and serves as the academic core of the combined Advocate Health enterprise.

Atrium Health is North Carolina's largest health system by patient volume and revenue, with Charlotte and Georgia operations projected at \$14.5 billion in revenue in 2026. In June 2025, Atrium opened The Pearl, a multi-billion dollar medical innovation district in Charlotte housing IRCAD North America and the second campus of Wake Forest University School of Medicine — Charlotte's first four-year medical school. In May 2026, Atrium announced a proposed strategic combination with WakeMed Health & Hospitals, the Triangle's leading community-based health system, which if completed would bring Atrium's network directly into UNC Health's primary geographic market.

For the Office of Innovation and Commercialization, Atrium Health presents a complex dual framing. It is the state's dominant health system by scale and a capital-intensive innovation investor, while also operating in a different primary geography than UNC — Charlotte and the Piedmont rather than the Triangle and eastern North Carolina. The proposed WakeMed combination, pending regulatory approval, would materially change that geographic calculus and warrants monitoring. Specific collaboration opportunities exist in cancer research geography, virtual care model validation, and Wake Forest's participation in the Carolinas Collaborative CTSA data-sharing infrastructure.

Sources: Atrium Health About Us [1]; Business North Carolina [2]; Advocate Health [3].

Basic Organizational Information

Field	Value
Full Name	Charlotte-Mecklenburg Hospital Authority (operating as Atrium Health)
Parent Organization	Advocate Health (Charlotte, NC)
Headquarters	1000 Blythe Boulevard, Charlotte, North Carolina, United States
Website	https://atriumhealth.org
Org Type	NC Hospital Authority; subsidiary of Advocate Health
Revenue	Charlotte and Georgia operations projected at \$14.5B in 2026; FY2024 \$12.59B; Advocate Health enterprise \$38.9B in 2025
Employees	Atrium Southeast: 43,000+; Advocate Health: 167,000
Hospitals	Atrium Southeast: 40; Advocate Health enterprise: 69
Care Locations	Atrium Southeast: 500+; Advocate Health: 1,000+
CEO (Advocate Health)	Eugene A. Woods, MBA, MHA, FACHE
Academic Core	Wake Forest University School of Medicine
EHR Platform	Epic (transitioned from Cerner; announced 2020)

Sources: Atrium Health About Us [1]; Business North Carolina [2]; Fierce Healthcare [4]; Advocate Health [3].

System Scale and Structure

Organizational Context: Atrium Health within Advocate Health

Atrium Health is one of three major operating divisions of Advocate Health, formed in December 2022 through the combination of Atrium Health and Advocate Aurora Health. The three divisions are: Advocate Health Care (Illinois, 11 hospitals); Aurora Health Care (Wisconsin); and Atrium Health (Carolinas, Georgia, and Alabama, 40 hospitals). Wake Forest University School of Medicine, which combined with Atrium Health in 2020, serves as the academic core for the entire Advocate Health

enterprise. Advocate Health is headquartered in Charlotte, making Atrium Health's Charlotte operations the functional headquarters of the nation's third-largest nonprofit integrated health system.

Charlotte and Southeast Hospital Network

The Atrium Health Charlotte network is anchored by Atrium Health Carolinas Medical Center, an academic medical center in Charlotte's Dilworth neighborhood that includes Levine Children's Hospital, Atrium Health Levine Cancer Institute, and Sanger Heart & Vascular Institute. The Charlotte network includes 11 hospitals in the greater Charlotte region, more than 900 care locations, and more than 1,400 physicians. The system operates 35 emergency departments, 35 urgent care locations, and 32 cancer care locations across its Southeast footprint.

Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist

The second major North Carolina component of Atrium Health is Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist, headquartered in Winston-Salem. Its clinical anchor is Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist Medical Center, an 885-bed tertiary-care, Level I Adult and Pediatric Trauma Center teaching hospital. The system includes Brenner Children's Hospital, five community hospitals, more than 300 primary and specialty care locations, and more than 2,700 physicians. Wake Forest University School of Medicine, with campuses in both Winston-Salem and Charlotte, provides the academic and research infrastructure for the entire Atrium Health enterprise.

The Pearl — Charlotte Medical Innovation District

The Pearl is a multi-billion dollar medical innovation district developed by a public-private partnership led by Atrium Health, Wexford Science & Technology, and Ventas, located in Charlotte's center city. The Pearl opened in June 2025 and is projected to generate more than 5,500 on-site and 11,500 total jobs in the region over 15 years. Key components include the Charlotte campus of Wake Forest University School of Medicine — Charlotte's first four-year medical school — and IRCAD North America, the exclusive North American headquarters of IRCAD, the global network of advanced surgical training facilities. IRCAD North America held its formal grand opening at The Pearl in September 2025. Industry partners at The Pearl include Siemens, Stryker, and Boston Scientific.

Proposed WakeMed Combination (May 2026)

On May 6–7, 2026, Atrium Health and WakeMed Health & Hospitals announced a proposed strategic combination. WakeMed is a Raleigh-based nonprofit health system with five hospitals and approximately 350 physicians, and is the Triangle's leading community-based health system. The proposed combination includes a \$2 billion investment in Wake County, creation of more than 3,300 new healthcare jobs, and the development of the state's largest nonprofit behavioral health network with more than 360 inpatient behavioral health beds. The agreement requires Wake County

commissioner approval, followed by review by the North Carolina attorney general and the Federal Trade Commission. No timeline for completion has been publicly specified. If completed, this combination would place Atrium Health directly in the Triangle market.

Sources: Atrium Health About Us [1]; Advocate Health [3]; Atrium Health/WakeMed Announcement [5]; The Pearl [6]; IRCAD North America [7]; Business North Carolina [2].

Quality, Rankings, and Accreditation

U.S. News Best Hospitals 2025–26

In the 2025–26 U.S. News & World Report Best Hospitals rankings released July 2025, Atrium Health earned two nationally ranked adult specialties. Atrium Health Carolinas Rehabilitation was ranked No. 12 nationally in rehabilitation — the fifth consecutive year in the top spots and the highest-ranking rehabilitation hospital in the Southeast. Atrium Health Carolinas Medical Center was recognized as the Best Hospital in the Charlotte metro region for the ninth consecutive year. Atrium Health also holds the most hospitals on U.S. News statewide Best Hospitals rankings in North Carolina of any single system.

Levine Children’s Hospital — 18th Consecutive Year

In October 2025, Atrium Health Levine Children’s Hospital was recognized as a Best Children’s Hospital by U.S. News & World Report for the 18th consecutive year — remaining the only children’s hospital in Charlotte to earn this designation. The hospital ranked in 7 pediatric specialties, with Top 25 national rankings in five specialties including a Top 10 ranking (No. 8) in cardiology and heart surgery.

Financial and Operational Performance

Atrium Health (Charlotte and Georgia operations) reported operating income of \$655 million through the first nine months of 2025, a 29 percent increase year over year, reflecting a 6.2 percent operating margin — well above the 1.1 percent median for nonprofit U.S. hospitals reported by Fitch Ratings. The full Advocate Health enterprise reported \$38.9 billion in total revenue and \$1.5 billion in operating income (4.0 percent margin) for the full year 2025. Fitch Ratings affirmed Atrium Health (NC) at AA with a stable outlook in October 2025.

Sources: Atrium Health newsroom [8]; Atrium Health Foundation [9]; Business North Carolina [2]; Fierce Healthcare [4].

Research Infrastructure

Wake Forest University School of Medicine

Wake Forest University School of Medicine is the academic core of the Atrium Health enterprise and of Advocate Health. It operates dual campuses in Winston-Salem and Charlotte (the latter housed at The Pearl, opened June 2025). The school is affiliated with Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist and ranks in the top third of U.S. medical schools in NIH funding. The school offers MD, MD/PhD, PhD, and graduate health professions programs across both campuses.

Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist Comprehensive Cancer Center (NCI-Designated)

The Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist Comprehensive Cancer Center is an NCI-designated Comprehensive Cancer Center — one of approximately 57 such centers in the country — first receiving NCI designation in 1974, making it one of the original designated centers. It is the only NCI-designated Comprehensive Cancer Center in western North Carolina. The cancer center is integrated under the unified name Atrium Health Levine Cancer, the largest cancer program in the Carolinas. The combined program has a shared catchment area of 30 counties across the Southeast, seeing more than 16,000 new cancer patients per year across 30-plus care locations, with 20 clinical sites accruing patients to research studies and 20 percent of enrolled patients living in rural areas. Atrium Health Levine Cancer offers more than 500 active clinical trials — described as more than any other cancer program in the Southeast.

Wake Forest Center for Artificial Intelligence Research (CAIR)

The Wake Forest Center for Artificial Intelligence Research, housed within the Wake Forest University School of Medicine at Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist, conducts applied AI research in health and medicine. CAIR issues joint pilot awards — including an inaugural \$50,000 joint award with UNC Charlotte's AI4Health Center awarded to a Wake Forest ophthalmology researcher for a vision-language model diagnostic tool for diabetic retinopathy. CAIR hosts a bi-annual colloquium and summer internship research program.

Carolinas Collaborative — CTSA Data Sharing

Wake Forest University is one of four CTSA institutions participating in the Carolinas Collaborative, a joint program that harmonizes electronic health record data across CTSA institutions at Wake Forest, Duke, UNC (via the UNC-RTI partnership), and the Medical University of South Carolina. The Carolinas Collaborative enables cross-institutional EHR data access for translational research and quality improvement. This is the most directly documented inter-institutional data infrastructure connecting the Atrium Health academic enterprise with UNC.

Sources: Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist Comprehensive Cancer Center [10]; Atrium Health Levine Cancer [11]; Wake Forest CAIR [12]; Duke CTSI Carolinas Collaborative [13].

Digital and AI Infrastructure

Epic EHR

Atrium Health operates Epic as its enterprise EHR across its Charlotte and Southeast operations, having announced the transition from Cerner to Epic in 2020. Active Epic integrations include a digital payments platform co-developed with Epic, launched in 2022, which processed more than \$19 million in digital patient payments between June 2022 and July 2023.

Virtual Edge and Hospital at Home

Atrium Health Virtual Edge is a comprehensive virtual care platform offering more than 30 programs across the care continuum, including hospital at home, telehealth for primary and specialty care, school- and community-based virtual clinics, virtual behavioral health, and asynchronous eVisits. The Hospital at Home program — Atrium’s signature virtual care initiative — provides hospital-level care to patients in their homes using twice-daily paramedic visits and video calls with providers, and is described as one of the nation’s largest hospital-at-home programs.

The Pearl as Innovation Infrastructure

The Pearl is described by CEO Eugene Woods as a platform for uniting “the world’s top medical technology companies” with surgeons, scientists, startups, and medical students. Industry partners Siemens, Stryker, and Boston Scientific have established presences at The Pearl alongside IRCAD North America and the Wake Forest School of Medicine Charlotte campus.

Sources: Becker’s Hospital Review [14]; Atrium Health Virtual Edge [15]; The Pearl [6].

Strategic Themes

- North Carolina’s largest health system by revenue, projected at \$14.5 billion in 2026 for Charlotte and Georgia operations, within Advocate Health’s \$38.9 billion enterprise.
- CEO Eugene Woods and The Pearl represent a multi-year strategic vision to make Charlotte a national destination for medical innovation.
- NCI-designated Comprehensive Cancer Center (Wake Forest, since 1974) integrated with Levine Cancer Institute as the largest cancer program in the Carolinas, with 500-plus clinical trials.

- Wake Forest University School of Medicine as a dual-campus academic engine linking Charlotte's innovation economy to Winston-Salem's established research base.
- Virtual Edge and Hospital at Home positioning Atrium as a documented national leader in virtual care delivery.
- Proposed WakeMed combination (announced May 2026, pending approval) — a \$2 billion investment and Triangle market entry.
- Fitch AA rating with stable outlook; operating margin of 6.2 percent significantly outperforming the nonprofit hospital median.
- Carolinas Collaborative participation linking Wake Forest's CTSA to UNC's CTSA in a shared EHR data-harmonization infrastructure.

Alignment with UNC Research

No formal OIC-level UNC–Atrium institutional partnership has been identified from the current source set. The WakeMed combination announcement significantly increases the urgency of monitoring Atrium's geographic trajectory.

Three Strategic Framing Pillars for UNC

Carolinas Collaborative and CTSA data infrastructure: Wake Forest's CTSA is a direct co-participant with the UNC-RTI CTSA partnership in the Carolinas Collaborative EHR data-sharing program. This is the most documented structural connection between UNC and the Atrium Health academic enterprise.

Cancer geography and trial access: The Atrium Health Levine Cancer program — NCI-designated, largest in the Carolinas, with 20 percent rural patient enrollment — and UNC Lineberger Comprehensive Cancer Center represent complementary North Carolina cancer geographies.

Innovation district and industry partnership model: The Pearl's model of co-locating industry partners (Siemens, Stryker, Boston Scientific), a medical school, and a surgical training center is the most developed industry partnership infrastructure at any North Carolina health system.

Specific UNC Research Fit Areas

- **Biomedical informatics and CTSA data:** Carolinas Collaborative creates direct structural overlap.
- **Oncology and clinical trials:** Geographic complementarity between Atrium Health Levine Cancer and UNC Lineberger.
- **Virtual care and implementation science:** Atrium's Hospital at Home program as a research and replication target.

- **Medical education and health workforce:** Parallel investments in NC health workforce capacity.
- **AI research and health informatics:** Wake Forest CAIR's UNC Charlotte joint award model.

Sources: Duke CTSI Carolinas Collaborative [13]; Atrium Health Levine Cancer [11]; Wake Forest CAIR [12].

Talking Points

Organizational Context

- Atrium Health is North Carolina's largest health system, part of Advocate Health — the nation's third-largest nonprofit health system with \$38.9 billion in revenue, 69 hospitals, and 167,000 employees.
- The Charlotte and Georgia operations are projected to generate \$14.5 billion in revenue in 2026, supported by a 6.2 percent operating margin.
- CEO Eugene Woods has built Atrium into one of the most financially and operationally aggressive health systems in the country.
- The proposed WakeMed combination signals active intent to expand from Charlotte into the Triangle.

Research and Innovation Relevance

- Wake Forest University School of Medicine is the academic core of a \$38.9 billion health enterprise.
 - The Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist Comprehensive Cancer Center has held NCI designation since 1974.
 - The Pearl is a documented industry partnership model — with Siemens, Stryker, Boston Scientific, and IRCAD already operating on-site.
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Risk and Caution Notes

- Revenue figures cited refer specifically to Charlotte-Mecklenburg Hospital Authority and Georgia operations, not full Advocate Health enterprise.
- Atrium Health is a North Carolina Hospital Authority — a public body — not a nonprofit corporation in the conventional sense.
- The proposed WakeMed combination is pending multiple regulatory approvals.

- The Carolinas Collaborative is a CTSA-funded data-sharing program; its existence does not imply OIC-level sponsored research relationships.
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Expected Report Angle and Positioning

Positioning Summary: Atrium Health should be framed as (1) North Carolina's largest health system and the Southeast operations unit of Advocate Health, the nation's third-largest nonprofit integrated health system; (2) the anchor of The Pearl, Charlotte's first medical innovation district; (3) an NCI-designated Comprehensive Cancer Center system with the largest cancer program in the Carolinas; (4) a documented leader in virtual care delivery; and (5) a system whose proposed May 2026 WakeMed combination represents the most consequential competitive and partnership development in the North Carolina health landscape.

References

- [1] Atrium Health — About Us — <https://atriumhealth.org/about-us>
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- [3] Advocate Health — About Advocate Health — <https://www.advocatehealth.org/>
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- [6] The Pearl — The Pearl Launches in Charlotte (June 2025)
- [7] The Pearl — IRCAD North America Grand Opening (September 2025)
- [8] Atrium Health Newsroom — U.S. News Best Hospital National Rankings (July 29, 2025)
- [9] Atrium Health Foundation — Levine Children's Hospital Best Children's Hospital (October 7, 2025)
- [10] Atrium Health Wake Forest Baptist — Comprehensive Cancer Center 50 Years (August 2024)
- [11] Atrium Health Levine Cancer — We Are Atrium Health Levine Cancer
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[14] Becker's Hospital Review — Atrium Health adopts digital payments from Epic (June 2024)

[15] Atrium Health — Virtual Edge

[16] Wake Forest — Informatics and Analytics, Department of Internal Medicine

[17] NC Health News — Charlotte-based Atrium Health Targets WakeMed (May 1, 2026)

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